

THE VEILWRACK: THE STILLING

Fourth Wall Gaming

CHAPTER 1 — THE GOLD BELOW



Dawn came up the western face of Lanternfall Spire the colour of old brass, and Vorrh stood on the diving stage with the wind worrying the wax seals of his breath-bottles and thought, as he always thought before a descent: *the dead go down, all of them, even mine.*

Below him the Undermist lay like a sea of molten gold, lambent, depthless, beautiful in the way that drowned things are beautiful. The Alar called its surface the skim, and they had charted it for a thousand years, and this morning it was two hundred meters higher than any chart said it should be. Nobody on the stage had remarked on that yet. Vorrh had learned, in his exile, that there were two kinds of silence: the kind people kept, and the kind that kept people. He was no longer always sure which one he was standing in.

The drum-master checked his tether — spliced sinew, cold-waxed, rated for a body and a half, which was the Deepway's old joke and not a joke at all. Above, on the survey perch, Kithrel of the Moults settled into the count-keeper's cradle with her dead flight's lane-tokens braided into her primaries, clicking faintly, a sound like small bones agreeing with each other.

"Contract's the edge," she called down. "Chart the pocket, sound the margins, come back. Esk's words. The commander pays for measurements, diver, not for heroics."

"I have never been paid for either," Vorrh said.

“Then you’ll feel right at home.” She began the count, slow and metronomic, the diver-tender’s pulse that would follow him down the tether like a second heartbeat: *one, and one, and one.*

He stepped off the stage and let the world take him.

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The descent was clean. That was the first wrongness, though he did not name it so until later: two hundred and eighty meters of falling dawn, the spire-root sliding past him scabbed with reef-bone and abandoned lamp-rings, and not one gust crossed him, not one shear, nothing. The air parted for him as courteously as a Crown agent’s smile. A diver of the Deepway is taught to mistrust an easy stair. Vorrh had been cast out of the Deepway for asking questions, but they had never managed to take the teaching back.

At depth he hung in his harness in the gold light coming up off the skim, and the still pocket stood off to the west of him like a guest who has arrived early to a funeral.

You could not see it, exactly. That was the obscenity of it. The Stilling had no edge the eye could fix — only a region where the brass light went somehow flat, where the air gave up the small ceaseless conversation that living air conducts with itself, and the world looked like a painting of the world. Beneath his dread, and he was honest enough to admit the dread, ran a thinner, worse thread, a yearning with a number on it in some Warden ledger somewhere: *I have heard you before, and I have wanted to hear you again every day since.*

He unstoppered the first sounding-rite instead.

The Mist-Rites of Carrowspar are humble sorcery, folk-craft, a few breath-borne syllables that go out into the murk and come back changed, and from the changing a trained ear reads distance, density, the architecture of vapour. Vorrh cast the first rite toward the pocket’s margin and the syllables went out true — and smeared. They came back to him like drowned men, their consonants eaten, their distances slurred into one another, useless. He hung in his harness and listened to his own craft fail and felt the fine hairs of his nape rise.

He cast again, and this time spent against the failure the last of what a diver hoards — the gambler's grace, the held favour, the luck a man burns when skill is not enough. It bought him nothing. The second casting died worse than the first.

But dying, it told him something. The early-failing syllables — the ones that should have scattered at random, eaten by random vapour — had all died *in the same direction*. Westward. Toward the pocket. As if something in the silence had reached out along each thread of sound and pinched it, one by one, with the unhurried thoroughness of a lamp-tender going down a ring of wicks.

"You are not weather," Vorrh said to the west, very quietly, in the tone the catechism reserves for things that might be listening. "Weather does not choose."

The silence did not answer. That, too, he would remember later, and understand differently.

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What he could measure, he measured, because Esk Veil-Torn paid for measurements and because numbers were the only prayer he had left. The pocket's upper margin rode at two hundred and eighty meters below the stage — twenty meters shallower than the commander's newest chart, a chart inked less than a season ago. He ran the figures twice. The chart was not wrong. The chart had been right, and then the world had moved.

And the margin itself would not hold still for him. Each time he fixed its edge against a lamp-ring or a knuckle of reef-bone, the flatness had crept, or withdrawn, or breathed — a tide-line, he thought, with a lurch of recognition, for he had spent his whole life beside the one tide the Alar know, the slow gold swell of the Undermist itself. The Stilling's edge was not a border. It was a shore. And shores belong to seas, and seas have movements of their own, and things that move in them.

Far above, threadbare with distance, Kithrel's count came down the tether: *and one, and one, and one*. The most ordinary sound in the sky. He had never in his life been so glad of anything so small.

Vorrh hung between the risen gold and the creeping silence, took out his survey slate, and wrote what no chart in the Veilwrack yet said: *Pocket top 280. Edge tidal — unfixed. Soundings die westward, all of them, together.*

Then, because he was Ossuin, and because the skim below him had risen two hundred meters like a thing swelling toward a surface, he wrote one line more, in the small precise hand the Deepway had taught him for the recording of deaths:

Something down here is closer than it was.

CHAPTER 2 — THE FUNERAL OF HOLLM



The skim had risen to four hundred meters, and Vorrh went down to meet it, and this part of the dive was on no contract and in no ledger, and he had known since before dawn that he was going to do it anyway.

The surface of the Undermist up close is not like gold at all. Gold is honest metal; it lies still. The skim moved — a slow iridescent crawl, currents of brass and chalcedony and a colour like lamplight through wax that has no name in any of the three kindreds' tongues, all of it turning over with the patience of something that has been digesting a world for longer than the Record runs. Carrowspar's catechism says the dead go down through it to the Worldlung's keeping. Vorrh had believed that once, entirely, the way a child believes in the floor.

He found the place by memory. Reef-bone to the north, the drowned lamp-ring westward, and below — months below, and one unsanctioned dive, and one snagged arm raised toward a surface it never reached — the place where he had found his brother.

Hollm. Named at their shared first descent: *the held breath*. Stair-cohort, wing-brother, betrothed of a lamp-tender of Lanternfall whose wedding had been set for the Wet. The Synod's record of his death read *Carried down, complete, sealed* — a proper funeral for a death no one had witnessed, of a body no one had carried. Vorrh had asked how

a record could be complete when he had been there and it wasn't. He had asked twice. The asking was his whole exile.

From the cold-wax wrapping at his breast he took the ring — spliced sinew, broken once, mended toward her — and the small waxed bone that wore it, on which he had written, in the recording hand, two words: *witnessed: Vorrh*.

“By the Stair and the wax and the long way down,” he said, “I will do this by the book they cast me out of. Let them say the form was wrong. Let them say the diver was wrong. They will not say it was not done.”

He began the cohort descent-rite alone, and that was his first mistake, and he made it on purpose.

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The rite is built for many voices. He had always known this the way one knows a doctrine; he learned it now the way one learns a wound. The descent-chant walks in three parts — the calling voice, the answering voice, and the cohort-silence between them, the held gap into which the answer must fall on the rest-length, exact, or the form is broken. One mouth cannot call and answer both. He tried. The first passage collapsed on the turn, his answering line arriving into a silence still warm from his own calling, graceless, late, *wrong*, and the gold turned over below him with sublime indifference.

He tried again, by the book, every syllable weighed, and broke it worse.

And hanging there with the ruin of the form in his mouth, Vorrh understood — with the cold, vertiginous clarity that comes to a man precisely when he can least afford it — what the failure *was*. The cohort-rite cannot be performed by one voice. Not poorly. Not at all. Structurally, doctrinally, in its very bones, it cannot. Which meant the Synod's record — *carried down, complete, sealed*, the rite performed entire for a body never found, by witnesses never named — described a thing that could not happen. The record was not mistaken. The record

was an impossibility, written down and sealed by men who knew the form better than anyone alive.

They had not papered over a death. They had papered over the *rite itself*.

“What did you hear that day,” he whispered to the gold, “that was worth all of this quiet?”

He set himself, a third time, into the calling passage. The chant went out over the skim. He reached the turn, and held the cohort-silence open — the gap where the answering voice belongs, the rest he could not fill —

— and the silence to the west *leaned in*.

There is no other rendering of it. The still pocket, the dead air, the flat region where his soundings had gone to die — it came up against the open gap of the rite and *held it*. Held the rest. Perfectly. Not a sound; the precise, fluent, deliberate *shape* of where a sound would be, sustained for the exact rest-length the form demands, the way a cantor who has sung a liturgy ten thousand times holds a caesura. The most beautiful answering-silence Vorrh had ever been given in his life, and it came from the thing that was eating the sky.

His chant broke. Not the form this time — the man. His voice cracked off the rest-length and scattered, and he grabbed for the tether like a fledgling, and somewhere in that long falling moment he reached for the one ordinary thing the world had left him, Kithrel’s count coming down the line, *and one, and one* —

The count was gone.

No tether-pulse. No metronome. Nothing above him and nothing below him and the great fluent attentive silence to the west, waiting, with perfect courtesy, for his next line.

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He did not give it the form. Some stubborn marrow-deep thing — the same thing that had asked the Synod its question twice — refused to

feed one more syllable of the Deepway's liturgy into whatever was down here practising it.

He finished the funeral in his own words. They were not good words. He said that Hollm had been the better diver and the worse cardplayer; that he had folded his wings toward a singing no one else had been permitted to hear, and that whatever had called him was a thief, whatever it was, however beautiful; that a lamp-tender on Lanternfall had been handed a sealed lie instead of a husband, and that this, of everything, remained unforgiven. He said the dead go down, all of them, even his. He unwound the cold-wax, and kept the ring, because the ring was mended toward *her* and was not his to give the dark.

The bone he gave to the gold.

It went under without a ripple, the way everything goes under, the way nine thousand went at Greywake — received, absorbed, kept. *Witnessed: Vorrh.* The only true line in the whole of the Synod's record, and he had had to write it himself.

"The count is broken," he said to the skim, to the west, to whatever held caesuras in the deep. "His count stopped at the wrong number and no one finished it. I will finish it. By the Stair and the wax — that one is mine."

His luck was spent to the last grace. His voice was gone to a rasp. Four hundred meters of unknown air stood between him and the stage, and his soundings were dead, and the silence had stopped leaning in — which ought to have been a comfort.

It was not a comfort. A thing that leans in can lean *after*. He took hold of the tether and began to climb.

CHAPTER 3 — THE FINGER OF SILENCE



The climb began badly and then taught him what badly meant.

Vorrrh was wrung out — voice gone, grace gone, arms full of the particular lead that follows grief performed under load — and he climbed the way tired divers climb, by rote, wings half-set to the updraught, trusting the tether-line the way one trusts a stair one has used all one's life. At two hundred and ninety meters the stair betrayed him.

He flew into dead air.

There was no warning, because warning is a property of living air — pressure, sound, the murmur of the world — and all of it stopped at once, as if he had climbed through a pane of glass into a painting. His wings bit nothing they understood. The tether-pulse vanished under his hand. The lamplight from the rings above came through flat and wrong, light with the life skinned off it, and the silence took him in the chest the way deep cold takes a man: not as absence but as *pressure*, immediate, total, interested.

The dead band lay straight across his tether-line. It had not been there at his descent. The pocket had moved — no. He understood even as he dropped, wings folding, letting his own weight pull him back down out of the flat horror into air that breathed: the pocket had not moved.

The pocket had *reached*.

He hung below the band gasping in the living air, and the catechism rose in him unbidden — *that the dark is answering back* — and he put it down, and did what Wardens pay for and the Deepway trains for. He traversed east, well clear, and looked at the thing properly, and the looking was the finest piece of survey work he would ever do, and he would have given anything not to be its only witness.

It was a finger.

Eight meters thick, perhaps, smooth-flanked as a windworked column, a bar of perfected stillness extruded from the western pocket's mass across two hundred meters of open sky. Not a front, not a tide-line, not weather. A *limb*. And its axis — he ran the line twice, three times, against the lamp-rings and the spire-root and the drowned geometry he had fixed all morning — its axis pointed, exactly, with a draughtsman's contempt for coincidence, at the patch of skim where he had performed his brother's funeral.

It had not drifted across his tether. It had reached out along the line of his rite — toward the place where a single voice had held the cohort-gap open, toward the spot where a waxed bone had gone into the gold — reached *for* it, along a bearing, to a destination. While he had hung at the skim giving the dark his own words, this had been above him the whole time, extended over his head like a listener's arm along the back of a pew.

And now, with the rite ended and the bone given, it was going home. He fixed its tip against a lamp-ring and watched. Half a meter to the minute, smooth, unhurried, the silence drawing back into the silence — a thing retiring, replete. *Done listening*.

The survey-slate was in his hand without his deciding it. The recording hand wrote: *Band is extrusion from W pocket. Axis bears on rite-site. Withdrawal ~0.5 m/min, begun after rite's end*. The letters were steady. He was not.

"You heard the whole thing," he said. His ruined voice made it a whisper, which felt, in the flat light off the finger's flank, hideously appropriate. "You held the rest-length. You *waited for the end*."

The finger withdrew, half a meter to the minute, and declined to be questioned, and that was the answer.

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Three hundred meters above, on the survey stage, Kithrel of the Moulthad a different problem, and the problem weighed eighteen stone and held the haul-crank.

The count had never stopped. That was the thing she could not make the drum-master understand. Her count had gone down the tether all morning, *and one, and one*, unbroken — she had kept counts through lane-storms and through a wing-mate’s death-scream and she had not broken this one — but for the better part of an hour the line had returned nothing. No pulse, no diver’s-echo. The tether ran taut into the brass haze and somewhere down its length her count was going into a place that ate it.

“Dead line means dead diver,” the drum-master said, not unkindly. He was Roak, Lanternfall-born, and he had hauled bodies before. His hands were already set. “We bring him up while there’s something to bring.”

“The line’s not dead, it’s *eaten*, and there’s a difference.” She put her hand flat on the crank, which between a Vael survey-flier and a Roak drum-master was nearly a declaration of war. The lane-tokens of her dead flight clicked in her primaries; she was aware of them; she had braided them there to be aware of them at moments precisely like this one. “I’ve flown survey on every Stilling since Greywake. The dead patches don’t drift, everyone knows the dead patches don’t drift — and that one *moved between my fixes*. Dead air that holds still is dead air. Dead air that *moves* is doing something.” She heard the word leave her before she could weigh it, and let it stand. “It’s *working*. And you do not haul a tether up through a thing that is working, because then I am explaining to Commander Esk Veil-Torn how we cheese-wired our own diver through the middle of it.”

The drum-master looked at the line. The line, taut and silent, declined to vote.

“Wait for the band to pass,” Kithrel said, quieter. “If it’s moving, it’s moving for a reason, and reasons end. He’s Ossuin. They don’t drown easy and they don’t panic ever. Keep your hands on the crank if it comforts you — but the first haul is mine to call. That’s drawn in the contract.”

It was not, in fact, drawn in the contract. It would be in the next one.

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The tip of the finger passed the lamp-ring bearing, and the world behind it came back on like a lamp itself — sound and shear and the blessed petty commerce of moving air. Vorrrh rounded the place where the silence had been, found the tether-line live again under his hand — *and one, and one*, faint, furious, unbroken; she had never stopped, all that time he had been deaf in the gold she had been counting into the thing that ate it — and something in his chest went loose at the ordinariness of it, which he was wise enough to recognize as the closest thing to rescue that morning was going to offer him.

He set his wings and climbed, clean and slow, out of the brass and into the day, to the last orange lamp of the lowest ring, where he hooked an arm through corroded metal and hung, breathing, alive, solvent in nothing but information.

And what information. He assembled it on the slate while his arms shook, in the recording hand, for Esk, who paid for measurements: *Pocket top 280, not 300. Skim risen to 400, not 600. The edge is a tide and will not chart. And the silence reaches toward sustained sound — deliberately, along a bearing, to a place — and withdraws when the sound is done.*

Four findings. Three of them made every chart in the Warden draft obsolete.

The fourth made obsolete something he did not yet have a word for, and the lack of the word followed him all the way up the last hundred meters like a finger laid along his spine.

CHAPTER 4 — WHAT THE DIVER SAID



Commander Esk Veil-Torn kept her chart-room in the old beacon-keeper's gallery on Lanternfall's western face, where the light came in late and brass-coloured through panes of scraped horn, and the walls were charts, and the charts were dying.

That was how Vorrh had thought of it since his first hour in the draft. Other commanders hung trophies. Esk hung the Greywake windlane, inked by some Moult chart-singer a decade gone, with its lane-shrines and its tally-knots and its margins annotated in three hands — and across it, in the Warden draft's flat red, the creeping season-lines of the Stilling that had swallowed it. Lane after lane along the gallery wall, each with its red tide-marks. A library of obituaries. She worked with her back to none of them. She had earned her deed-name going into the Greywake silence after her wing-sister, and had come out alone, torn, carrying the body anyway, and it was said in the draft that she had hung that chart where visitors would have to look at it so that she would never have to explain herself twice.

She heard his report standing, arms folded, and did not interrupt once. That was her way; she was economical, scrupulously fair, allergic to speeches, and she paid for measurements.

He gave her measurements.

"Your charts put the pocket's top at three hundred meters. It rides at two hundred and eighty. The chart isn't in error — the chart was

right when it was inked, this season. The pocket has come up twenty meters since.” He laid the survey slate on her table, turned for her reading. “Your charts put the skim at six hundred. It stands at four hundred. And the pocket’s edge cannot be charted at all, by me or anyone, because it is not a border. It moves between fixes. It’s a tide-line, Commander. We have all been drawing shores on maps and calling them walls.”

Esk’s eyes went along the slate line by line. “And the soundings?”

“Dead. All of them. The rites smear and fail — and they fail westward, every casting, together, toward the pocket.” He paused, and then gave her the rest, because he had decided on the climb that she would have all of it. “It reaches, Commander. While I was at the skim it extruded a limb of dead air eight meters thick across two hundred meters of open sky. I flew into it on the ascent. When I cleared it and fixed its line, its axis bore exactly on the patch of skim where I was working. It reached toward a sustained sound, along a bearing, to a place. And when the sound ended, it withdrew — half a meter to the minute, smooth, like a man drawing back his hand from a table.”

The chart-room was quiet. Below the horn panes, faint and ceaseless, the evening commerce of the spire went on: wings, pulley-squeal, a lamp-crew calling its ring-count down the western face.

“Toward a sustained sound,” Esk said. “What sound?”

He could have said *survey casting*. The slate would have borne him out; she would never have caught the seam. He was aware of the door standing open in the lie, lamplit, comfortable — and aware too, with the ring’s small weight against his breastbone, of a Synod record that read *complete, sealed*, and of what records like that one cost the people downstream of them.

“A funeral,” Vorrh said. “The dive I came here to make. I performed the descent-rite at the skim for my stair-cohort brother, who went below it on my last sanctioned dive and was never carried down. The Deepway’s record says otherwise. The record describes a rite that cannot be performed — I know that now; I tried it alone, by the book, twice, and the form will not break the way the record says it bent.

While I held the cohort-gap open, the silence held it with me. On the rest-length. Fluently. Like a voice that knew the liturgy.” His own voice was still a rasp; it made the words sound older than they were. “You contracted a surveyor who would tell you the truth. That’s the truth, all of it, including the parts that come out of my own grave-debts. I tell you the truth — that’s why I fly.”

Esk looked at him for a long moment, with the dying lanes of a decade hung at her back.

“That’s why you fly for *me*,” she said, which from Esk Veil-Torn was a commendation with full honours. She turned the slate face-down, deliberately, the gesture of a woman closing one ledger and opening a worse one. “Then I’ll pay truth with truth, diver, because you’ve earned the bad half of this. You’re not the only count on this spire.”

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“Tilve Wickmend,” Esk said. “Lamp-tender, western face. The crews call her the hushed lampwright — she hasn’t spoken in two years, not since a tethered dive below the skim. She still lights every lamp, to the minute. And every night, on the lowest ring, she counts. The same count, the diver’s count, eighty-one beats, and stops. Eighty-one, and stops. Two years, and the wardens of that watch will tell you it has never varied by one breath.” Esk’s arms were still folded. “Last night it went to eighty-two.”

The lamp was the loudest thing in the room for a while.

“Last night,” Vorrh said.

“While you were below.” Her voice stayed level, economical, fair; her eyes did not leave him. “First change in two years, the same night an Ossuin diver holds a funeral-rite at the skim and the silence answers it back. I command a survey draft, Vorrh. I am paid to mistrust coincidence, and I find I cannot afford this one.”

A diver’s count. Stopped at the wrong number, two years, on the western face — the face above his rite, the face whose lamps had burned over every meter of his descent. *His count stopped at the wrong*

number and no one finished it. I will finish it. He had sworn that to the gold not twelve hours past, and the gold, it seemed, had not been the only thing listening; the sky had its own broken counts, and they were moving.

He said none of it. Not yet. The ring lay against his breastbone like a held breath.

“There’s a girl in my draft,” Esk went on, “who talked my drummer out of hauling you up through the middle of that limb — on her own authority, which she did not have, and which I have just given her retroactively because she was right. She’s offered to stand the night watches on the western face. Unpaid.” A dry flicker. “The Mould does not offer unpaid anything, so you might consider what she thinks she’s watching over.”

“Commander,” Vorrh said, “what is your question?”

Because there was one. He had learned her that well at least: Esk Veil-Torn did not deal in revelations, she dealt in decisions, and she had not turned that slate face-down to share his awe.

She unfolded her arms. Behind her the dead lanes hung in their red tide-marks, and below the horn panes the lamp-crews called their counts, and somewhere down the western face a silent woman was lighting the evening rings on schedule, eighty-two beats into a count whose ending no one living knew.

“The count moved when you gave the silence what it wanted,” Esk said. “So you tell me, diver — you that it answered. The lamp-crews say the full diver’s count runs to one hundred and eight. What happens when she gets there?” The brass light through the horn was going out of the room by degrees, the way it went out of everything. “And do I hope for it — or do I post wardens to stop it?”

The lamps came on, ring below ring below ring, down into the dark.